

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN BELARUS

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Belarus is a closed and severely repressive state — one where civil society was crushed after 2020, hundreds of thousands were forced into exile, and thousands were imprisoned, and where open environmental organising is dangerous and public oversight extremely limited. It is a heavily forested Eastern European nation carrying two heavy burdens and holding one great treasure. It bore the brunt of the 1986 **Chernobyl** disaster more than any other country: most of the fallout fell here, a tenth of the land and of the people remain in affected territories, and a vast contaminated zone in the south, emptied of its people, has become a living laboratory of radiation. It carries a heavy **state-run logging industry**, extensive drained **peatlands** that smoulder and emit carbon, and a new **Russian-built nuclear plant** raised, against all irony, in the very country Chernobyl harmed most. And it holds, in **Belovezhskaya Pushcha**, the last great primeval forest of the European plain — a shared treasure straddling the border with Poland, where the European bison, once hunted to extinction in the wild, has been painstakingly brought back. There is no landmark community victory to point to, and no one inside can safely resist. But the world has a genuine stake in these things, and the tools to defend them, from outside, are real.

Those who would defend Belarus's environment cannot do so safely inside, but the tools from outside are real. Belovezhskaya Pushcha is a **World Heritage Site** shared with Poland, defensible through **UNESCO and transboundary conservation**. The state logging industry's timber can be scrutinised and contested under **international timber-legality and sustainability standards** — the certification and import rules that markets and buyers abroad enforce. The Russian-built nuclear plant touches **international and regional nuclear-safety frameworks** — the IAEA, the stress tests, the concern of neighbouring states. The drained, smouldering peatlands can be pressed for protection through the **international wetland and climate frameworks** — Ramsar and the climate conventions. The world's **scientific attention** to the Chernobyl legacy and the forest grounds it all, and **rigorous documentation** — satellite imagery, published science — needs no one inside. And the **exile and diaspora networks** carry the case where those within cannot speak. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. Belarus is closed and severely repressive: civil society was crushed, hundreds of thousands driven into exile, thousands imprisoned, and open environmental work inside is dangerous. The Chernobyl contamination is vast and largely permanent — managed and studied, not reversed. The primeval forest is pressed by logging and a militarised border, and cooperation across that border is strained. There is no landmark victory to promise. And, above all, no one inside can be exposed. So the work must be external, scientific, transboundary, and diaspora-borne, strictly environmental, protecting anyone inside absolutely — and the honest prize is the international defence of a world-treasured forest, the scrutiny of the logging and the nuclear, and the pressing of the peatlands' protection, not a project stopped from within.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot safely resist inside a state that jails and exiles those who dissent, and you must never ask anyone to. What can be done is to defend Belarus's environment from outside: document the harm, invoke the World Heritage and transboundary protection of the forest, scrutinise the logging against international standards and the nuclear against the safety frameworks, press the peatlands' protection through the wetland and climate conventions, and let exile and international voices and the world's science carry it —

while protecting everyone inside absolutely.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Belarus is one of the most closed and dangerous settings in this guide, and honesty about that is the first and gravest discipline. This is not a fight you win by domestic organising — that has been crushed. It is an external, scientific, transboundary, and diaspora-borne effort whose realistic prize is international defence and scrutiny, not a stop. Enter it understanding that no project contested is worth a person imprisoned, and that the safety of everyone inside comes before every other consideration.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power rests with a closed, repressive state and its state enterprises, in a system where civil society is crushed and public oversight is minimal. The decisions resisters can reach are external — taken in the **World Heritage and conservation bodies**, in the **markets and certifiers** that govern timber, in the **international and regional nuclear-safety frameworks**, in the **wetland and climate conventions**, and among the **world's scientists and the exile networks** who can act from outside. Map which of these you can reach safely.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The logging, the nuclear plant, and the peatland drainage advance by state decision; there is no safe domestic hearing to contest. Resisters enter where the outside world touches the harm: the forest's World Heritage status, the timber's markets and certification, the nuclear plant's safety frameworks and the neighbouring states' concern, the wetland and climate conventions. Each is a point of leverage reached from outside.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the timber: where the state logging's wood is sold, and what legality and sustainability standards those markets enforce. Follow the nuclear: which international and regional safety frameworks the plant touches, and which neighbouring states are concerned. Follow the forest and the wetlands: what World Heritage, transboundary, wetland, and climate protections apply. The leverage lies in the international status of the forest, the standards on the timber, the safety frameworks on the nuclear, and the conventions on the wetlands.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight is minimal and unfree. The watchers resisters can engage are external: UNESCO and the conservation bodies, the timber certifiers and market regulators, the IAEA and regional nuclear-safety bodies, the Ramsar and climate frameworks, the world's scientists, and the exile and diaspora networks. These are the institutions a careful, external case is built to reach.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Belarusian effort yields a domestic "win," and honesty requires saying so — civil society is crushed and the harms are state-driven. What the external tools realistically deliver is defence and scrutiny: a World Heritage forest watched and its logging exposed, the timber's markets pressed on legality, the nuclear

plant's safety questioned before regional bodies, the peatlands raised in the wetland and climate frameworks. The single most decisive move is **rigorous, open-source documentation** — satellite imagery, published science — because every external lever responds to credible evidence, and because such evidence needs no one inside and cannot be suppressed. Nothing here is fast, and no project is likely to be stopped from within. But a world treasure and a shared border give the international community a genuine reason to engage.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the logging of the primeval forest, the peatland drainage and smouldering, the nuclear-safety risk, the Chernobyl legacy. **What international status or standard does it touch?** — World Heritage, timber legality, nuclear safety, wetland or climate convention. **Who outside shares the interest?** — Poland and the neighbouring states, the conservation and scientific bodies, the timber markets, the diaspora. **Which external channel reaches it?** — UNESCO, a certifier, a safety framework, a convention. **How is everyone inside kept safe?** — the overriding question, answered by keeping all work external and exposing no one. Pick the harm where the international handle is clearest and safest.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, all from open, external sources. **Layer one: the harm** — the logging documented by satellite, the peatland drainage and fires, the nuclear-safety concerns, the forest's condition. **Layer two: the status and the standard** — the World Heritage designation, the timber-legality and sustainability rules, the nuclear-safety frameworks, the wetland and climate conventions the harm offends. **Layer three: the channel and the protection** — which external body to reach, and the absolute rule that no person inside is named, exposed, or endangered. A case built on satellite imagery and published science — needing no one inside — is one no closed state can suppress.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: satellite imagery of the logging and peatlands, the published science on the forest and the Chernobyl zone, the nuclear-safety analyses. Gather the **status-and-standard record**: the World Heritage designation, the timber-legality and certification rules, the IAEA and regional safety frameworks, the Ramsar and climate conventions. Gather the **channel record**: the conservation and scientific bodies, the timber markets and certifiers, the neighbouring states, the diaspora. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm every source is external and open, and that nothing traces to a person inside.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE INTERNATIONAL AND DIASPORA COALITION

The coalition here is external, because it must be. Build it from the **exile and diaspora networks**, who can speak where those inside cannot; the **international conservation and scientific bodies** engaged with the forest and Chernobyl; the **neighbouring states — Poland above all — and their conservation and nuclear-safety concerns**; and the **timber-market, certification, and climate campaigners** who can reach the standards. Build carefully, protect every source, and never in a way that draws in or exposes anyone

inside the country.

STEP 4: INTERNATIONAL, CONSERVATION & SAFETY LEVERS — CONTESTING THE HARM FROM OUTSIDE

Set expectations honestly: the levers are external, indirect, and partial, and the harms are state-driven, so the prize is defence and scrutiny, not a stop.

The World Heritage and Transboundary Forest Defence

Belovezhskaya Pushcha is a **World Heritage Site** shared with Poland, and its logging and degradation can be contested through **UNESCO and transboundary conservation** — the international attention, the shared-heritage obligations, and the neighbouring state's stake. Watch it, document it, and raise it with the bodies that guard it.

The Timber and Nuclear Standards

The state logging's timber can be scrutinised under **international timber-legality and sustainability standards** — the certification and import rules markets abroad enforce — and the Russian-built nuclear plant under **international and regional nuclear-safety frameworks** and the concern of neighbouring states. Press the harm through the standards its outputs and infrastructure must answer to.

The Wetland, Climate, and Scientific Frameworks

The drained peatlands can be raised for protection through the **wetland (Ramsar) and climate conventions**, and the whole case grounded in the **world's scientific attention** to the forest and the Chernobyl legacy. Pursued together — the forest, the standards, and the frameworks — these external levers defend and scrutinise the harm while every person inside is protected absolutely.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For UNESCO and the conservation bodies:** here is a World Heritage forest under logging pressure, and here is the shared-heritage obligation. **For the timber markets and certifiers:** here is timber that may fail the legality and sustainability standards you enforce. **For the nuclear-safety frameworks and neighbouring states:** here is a plant that touches regional safety, and here are the concerns. **For the wetland and climate frameworks:** here are peatlands whose drainage offends the conventions. **The golden rule:** keep everything external and strictly environmental, argue the status and the standards, and protect every name inside absolutely.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media matters, carried entirely from outside. Frame the story around the **world treasure and the shared heritage:** the last primeval forest of the European plain under threat, the timber and the nuclear questioned, the Chernobyl legacy studied. Carry it through international conservation and scientific outlets, the neighbouring states' press, and the diaspora networks. A few cautions govern everything: never name or endanger anyone inside; rely on satellite imagery and published science; keep it factual and strictly environmental; and let the forest, the science, and the standards carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message external, documentary, and absolutely protective of anyone inside.

8A — To UNESCO / a World Heritage body: document the logging or degradation of Belovezhskaya Pushcha and invoke the shared-heritage obligation.

8B — To a timber certifier or market regulator: present the evidence and ask how the state timber meets the legality and sustainability standards.

8C — To the IAEA or a regional nuclear-safety body: set out the nuclear-safety concerns and request scrutiny.

8D — To a neighbouring state (Poland and others): raise the transboundary forest and nuclear concerns and ask for engagement.

8E — To a wetland (Ramsar) or climate framework: connect the peatland drainage to the conventions and request attention.

8F — To the international scientific and conservation networks: share the documented case and ask for support.

8G — To the exile and diaspora networks: share the case and ask for amplification and safe channels.

8H — To the international public: summarise the world-treasure cause and the harms, and ask for pressure — never exposing anyone inside.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: pull the open satellite imagery of the logging or peatlands and the published science; write the one-page world-treasure case; identify the single strongest external channel — usually UNESCO, a timber certifier, or a neighbouring state. **The fastest-moving levers:** the World Heritage status, the timber standards, and the nuclear-safety frameworks. **Emergency coalition-building:** reach the diaspora, the conservation bodies, and Poland's conservation networks first — they act safely from outside. Throughout, expose no one inside.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but closed and dangerous: a repressive state, crushed civil society, state-driven harms. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not a stop, but defence and scrutiny through the levers the closure cannot reach. Lean on the World Heritage status, the timber and nuclear standards, and the wetland and climate frameworks, all pursued from outside. And accept the honest possibility of losing on any front — the logging may continue, the plant may run — while still defending the forest and documenting the harm, and protecting, always and above all, the people inside.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Distinguish the ordinary drive of a state industry from capture — logging steered to enrich insiders, deals shielded from scrutiny. Where capture appears, respond only through the **external channels:** the World Heritage bodies, the timber certifiers, the safety frameworks, the documented record carried by exile voices and science. Never through domestic action. **On safety and protection:** this governs everything. Belarus crushed its civil society, exiled hundreds of thousands, and imprisoned thousands. Work through the international, scientific, transboundary, and diaspora channels entirely; never expose or endanger anyone

inside; treat their safety as the first and overriding consideration; frame the work as international conservation and science; and handle the state, the border, and the geopolitics only through the documented international record. Protection is not one concern among others — it is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, all from outside. The documented harm feeds the World Heritage defence, the timber and nuclear scrutiny, and the wetland-and-climate case at once; the international and diaspora coalition organises alongside; the media carries the world-treasure frame throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, assemble the satellite and scientific documentation and identify the strongest external channels; **months two to six**, engage UNESCO, the timber and nuclear frameworks, the neighbouring states, and the conventions, and build the diaspora coalition; **beyond**, sustain the external defence and scrutiny. The core discipline: external, scientific, strictly environmental, and absolute in protecting anyone inside.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Belarus is among the most closed and dangerous grounds in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a harm can be stopped from within, or that organising is safe, or that oversight is free — none of that is true, and civil society has been crushed. What it claims is narrower and real: that the last primeval forest of the European plain is a World Heritage treasure the world has an obligation to defend; that the state timber answers to international legality and sustainability standards; that the nuclear plant touches regional safety frameworks and the concern of neighbouring states; that the peatlands can be raised in the wetland and climate conventions; and that all of this can be pursued from outside — through UNESCO, the standards, the frameworks, the world's science, and the diaspora — without ever exposing a single person inside. The levers are external and partial, and the prize is defence and scrutiny, not a stop from within. But for a closed and repressive state that holds a world treasure, that external, scientific, strictly-environmental, protective work is not a lesser ambition — it is the only responsible and effective one.